

THE ARRAY

A SHORT FILM SCRIPT

FADE IN:

EXT. THE ARRAY, DESERT - DAWN

A field of satellite dishes, forty of them, arranged in a vast spiral across cracked desert flats, most tilted at dead angles, rusted still. Only one moves, slow, searching, alone against a sky bleeding orange at the horizon.

*SUPER: DECOMMISSIONED LISTENING STATION 4, YEAR TWO OF
STAND-DOWN*

INT. CONTROL BUNKER - CONTINUOUS

A cramped underground room, half its screens dark, cables taped rather than run properly. DR. IRIS CHEN (30s, government badge long expired, hasn't left in weeks) sits wrapped in a blanket, headphones on, eyes closed, listening.

A waveform crawls across her one working monitor. Rises. Repeats. Rises again. Exactly the same shape, every 11 minutes, for longer than she's willing to say out loud.

She opens her eyes. Writes in a physical notebook, page after page of them already filled: DAY 214. STILL THERE.

INT. CONTROL BUNKER - LATER

A satellite phone rings, the only device in the room that looks new. Iris stares at it three rings before answering.

IRIS

Chen.

VOICE (V.O.)

(clipped, official)

Dr. Chen. Station Four was
decommissioned eighteen months ago.
Continued occupancy is a violation
of...

IRIS

There's a signal.

A pause on the line.

VOICE (V.O.)

There is no signal, Doctor. Station
Four's array was never operational for
deep-range reception. You know that
better than anyone.

IRIS

I know what I'm hearing.

VOICE (V.O.)

Pack your equipment. Transport arrives
in six hours.

The line goes dead. Iris looks at the waveform. It rises again,
precisely on schedule, indifferent to her deadline.

EXT. THE ARRAY, DISH 7 - DAY

Wide shot: Iris, tiny, climbing the maintenance ladder of the
one working dish, forty feet up, wind dragging at her coat, the
spiral of dead dishes spread out below her like a fossil.

She reaches the receiver housing, opens a panel with hands that
have done this a hundred times. Recalibrates something by hand,
analog, stubborn, patient.

INT. CONTROL BUNKER - LATER

The waveform on her monitor sharpens, cleaner now, the shape more defined. Not noise. Structure. Iris leans in close, breath held.

Beneath the repeating rise, a smaller pattern nested inside it, a signal within the signal. She scrawls numbers fast, hand shaking now, not from cold.

IRIS

*(to herself, barely
audible)*

You're not weather. You're not a
satellite. You're...

She doesn't finish the sentence. Doesn't need to.

EXT. THE ARRAY, ACCESS ROAD - DUSK

Wide, flat shot: a convoy of two black transport trucks, headlights on, crawling across the desert toward the station, dust rising behind them in a long orange plume against the fading light.

INT. CONTROL BUNKER - CONTINUOUS

Iris hears the engines, faint, through the bunker's thin walls. Looks at the notebook, two hundred and fourteen pages of a truth nobody above her wanted recorded. Looks at the transmitter panel beside her monitor, unused in a decade, dust thick on its switches.

She makes a choice. Flips it live. Keys a broadcast, wide-band, unencrypted, everything, all of it, out into open air where anyone could catch it.

IRIS (CONT'D)

*(into the mic, steady
now)*

Station Four, unauthorized
transmission. If anyone is receiving
this, the signal is real. Day two-
fourteen. It's still there. It's
still...

The bunker door blows open behind her. Light floods in. She doesn't turn around, doesn't stop talking, gets three more words out before,

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. THE ARRAY - NIGHT, LATER

Wide shot, held a long time: the field of dishes, all of them dark now, one truck idling by the bunker entrance, its light the only warmth in frame.

And on Dish 7, forty feet up, a single receiver light still blinks, on schedule, uninterrupted, listening to something that never asked anyone's permission to exist.

FADE OUT.

END.